

Alpaca AI Trading Agents Hackathon

Organized by lablab.ai × Alpaca | Fully Online

Official Page: <https://lablab.ai/ai-hackathons/alpaca-ai-trading-agents-hackathon>

Dates	28 August 2026 – 4 September 2026 (7 days)
Format	Online only — join from anywhere
Prize Pool	\$6,000 total
Team Size	1 to 6 people

What This Hackathon Is

You build an AI trading agent that can trade on its own — using Alpaca's platform. Alpaca is a company that lets apps buy and sell stocks, options, ETFs, and crypto through an API. In this hackathon, everything runs in a **paper trading** environment — meaning fake money, real market data. No real money is used. No credit card is needed.

What You Must Build (Core Requirements)

- **Autonomous agent** — Your AI agent must be able to make trading decisions on its own using Alpaca's Trading API.
- **Use MCP or CLI** — Your project must use either Alpaca's MCP server or its CLI tool (command-line tool).
- **Options trading** — Your trading strategy must include options trading (not just stocks).

The Challenge, simply put: Build an AI agent that decides when to buy or sell (using options strategies), test it in the paper trading environment, and show how well it performs during the competition.

Account Rules — Read Carefully

While building: You can use any Alpaca paper trading account to practice and test your agent.

For final submission: You must create a brand-new Alpaca paper account made just for this hackathon. If you submit using an old or reused account, you will not be judged.

Starting balance: Your competition account must start with exactly \$100,000 (fake money).

Also required: A one-page write-up explaining your AI logic, your risk controls, and how you used Alpaca's tools.

Prizes

Rank	Prize	Amount
1st Place	First Place	\$2,500

2nd Place	Second Place	\$1,500
3rd Place	Third Place	\$1,000

Bonus: Social Engagement Prize

2 extra teams will each win **\$500** (for the team) plus a **1-month Algo Trader Plus subscription for every team member** — just for posting about your building process on X or LinkedIn while tagging lablab.ai and Alpaca. You can submit up to 5 posts.

Important Money Rules

- You must be 18 or older to win a prize.
- Prizes are paid to a person, not a team — if your team wins, one person is chosen to receive the money (or the team can split it with Finance ahead of time).
- You'll need to submit tax forms (W-9 for US, W-8BEN for non-US) plus a photo ID and bank details before getting paid.
- Payment happens within 90 days after the event ends, once your documents are approved.
- US winners earning over \$600 get a 1099-MISC tax form. Non-US winners may have 30% automatically withheld unless a tax treaty applies.

How You Will Be Judged

Criteria	What It Means
P&L Performance	How well your agent actually performed (profit/loss) during the competition, in the paper trading environment.
Technology Implementation	How well you used Alpaca's Trading API, MCP server, and CLI to build a working autonomous trading agent.
Creativity & Originality	How original your trading strategy and agent's approach is.
Presentation & Execution	How clearly you explain and demo your project, and your reasoning behind the strategy.
Social Engagement (bonus)	Quality and reach of your public posts about your building process (for the bonus prize only).

What You Need to Submit

- Project title, short description, long description, technology & category tags
- Cover image
- Video presentation
- Slide presentation
- Public GitHub repository (your code)
- Live demo application link
- Application URL

- **Your Alpaca paper trading account ID** (required — this is how judges check your trading results)
- Up to 5 social media post links (optional, for the bonus prize)

How to Join — Step by Step

1. Register on the lablab.ai website (the link is at the top of this document).
2. Also join the lablab.ai Discord server — both are required.
3. Click the 'Enroll' button on the hackathon page.
4. Read the Hackathon Guidelines, the Getting Started Guide, and the Rule Book.
5. Find teammates (1–6 people per team) on the dashboard or Discord — or work solo.
6. Build your project between 28 August and 4 September 2026.
7. Submit everything listed above before submissions close.

Event Schedule (Times in GMT+3)

Time	What Happens
Aug 28, 6:00 PM	Hackathon Kick-off
Aug 28, 6:05 PM	lablab.ai Opening words
Aug 28, 6:10 PM	Alpaca Opening words
Aug 28, 6:15 PM	Introduction to the Challenge
Aug 28, 6:25 PM	Hackathon Guide
Aug 28, 7:00 PM	Discord Q&A session
Sep 4, 6:00 PM	End of Submissions — deadline

Bottom Line

This is a finance / trading hackathon — not environmental or marine-related. It has no connection to the AAA project. If your team joins this one, it would be a separate, new project built from scratch around AI trading agents and options strategies on Alpaca's platform, not an extension of existing work.

Source: <https://lablab.ai/ai-hackathons/alpaca-ai-trading-agents-hackathon> | Compiled for Abdulla Tamimi | Organized by lablab.ai and Alpaca.